

People operating boats and ships travelling to Australia need to be aware of new reporting rules that came into effect on 18 June 2026. The changes apply to both commercial vessels, such as cargo ships, and non-commercial vessels, including private yachts and recreational boats.

#### New health reporting requirements for commercial vessels

Commercial vessel operators must now provide updated health information before arriving in Australian waters.

Under the new rules, operators must report if anyone on board has experienced new shortness of breath within the past 21 days. This symptom has been added to the existing list of reportable signs, which already includes fever, coughing, skin rashes and unusual bleeding.

The Australian Government has also updated several reporting forms used by vessel operators, including the Pre-Arrival Report (PAR), Human Health Update (HHU) and Additional Health Questions form.

In addition, offline reporting forms have been refreshed with the latest information on shipping agents, Australian and international ports, countries, and ballast water management systems.

Commercial vessel operators can download the updated forms and read further guidance through the [Maritime and Aircraft Reporting System \(MARS\) offline forms](#).

#### New biofouling reporting requirements for non-commercial vessels

Private and recreational vessel operators will now be asked additional questions about biofouling when completing their mandatory PAR.

Biofouling occurs when marine plants, algae or animals attach to a vessel's hull and equipment. These organisms can potentially introduce pests and diseases into Australian waters.

Under the new requirements, non-commercial vessel operators must:

- Declare how they manage biofouling through the [Non-Commercial Vessel Web Portal](#)
- Possess supporting documents if they use approved [biofouling management](#) plans or other recognised management methods
- Answer further questions if they cannot show acceptable biofouling management practices
- Report any plans to carry out in-water cleaning while in Australian waters and update their report if those plans change.

Biosecurity officers may use this information to assess potential risks and determine whether any additional actions are needed to protect Australia's marine environment.

#### Why the changes matter

The updates will help strengthen Australia's biosecurity and public health protections by improving information collected before vessels arrive.

Operators should make sure they understand the new requirements and provide accurate information before entering Australian waters.

Need more information?

For further advice, contact the department's National Maritime Centre:

- Phone (within Australia): 1300 004 605
- Phone (outside Australia): +61 8 8201 6185
- Email: National Maritime Centre [maritimenc@aff.gov.au](mailto:maritimenc@aff.gov.au)
- Visit [Vessels](#).

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